

The Goophered Grapevine

Charles W. Chesnutt · 1887

First published: The Atlantic Monthly, Aug 1887

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
4. Whole-book test and answer key
5. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Conjure_Woman/The_Goophered_Grapevine (revision 14117353), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 10–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). Middle School prompts use the full text when the grade tags include 6–8; otherwise teacher-selected passages. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 1 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Goophered Grapevine suggest about slavery and its memory?
- What does The Goophered Grapevine suggest about storytelling as resistance?
- What does The Goophered Grapevine suggest about race and economics?

Objectives

- Cite textual evidence to support analysis of what the text says explicitly and implicitly.
- Determine themes and analyze their development over the course of the story.
- Analyze how characters, setting and point of view interact.
- Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in the text.
- Write arguments to support claims with clear reasons and relevant evidence.

Standards and frameworks

- **Common Core:** RL.7.2, RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.7.1, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4
  Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org
- **Indiana 2023:** 7.RC.2, 7.RC.3, 7.W.1, 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.RC.2, 9-10.RC.3, 9-10.RC.9, 9-10.RC.12, 9-10.W.1, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.4, 11-12.RC.11, 11-12.RC.13, 11-12.W.1
  Indiana Academic Standards, English/Language Arts (2023), IDOE

- **Dual Credit (Indiana College Core):** ICC-WC-1.1, ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.7
  Indiana College Core, Written Communication outcomes 1.1–1.7 (CHE guidance); ICC-WC-x IDs are ours
- **AP:** AP-LIT.CHR, AP-LIT.SET, AP-LIT.STR, AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.FIG, AP-LIT.LAN
  AP English Literature and Composition big ideas (our summaries; apcentral.collegeboard.org)
- **Cambridge International:** CAIE-9695.AO1, CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4, CAIE-9695.AO5
  Cambridge International AS & A Level Literature in English 9695 assessment objectives (our summaries; cambridgeinternational.org)
- **Liber et Libri program outcomes:** LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1
  Liber et Libri program outcome, not an official standard

Primary codes: RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, RL.7.2
Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Middle School through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	The Goophered Grapevine	1 × 90 min (90 min)	*slavery and its memory* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: The Goophered Grapevine

Focus: a story told to protect a livelihood

Content note (slavery, heavy dialect, a racial slur used by the characters): Sensitive content: Slavery; heavy dialect; a racial slur used by the characters. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. The text quotes racial slurs in period dialogue: decide in advance that no one reads them aloud, and name why the author records them.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes slavery; heavy dialect; a racial slur used by the characters.
Suggested language: "Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?"

Teacher only · spoilers

A white Northerner, John, considers buying a run-down North Carolina vineyard. Julius McAdoo, a formerly enslaved man, tells him it is 'goophered' (conjured): before the war, an enslaved man named Henry ate its grapes, and his life rose and fell with the vines until he died. John buys anyway and later suspects Julius told the tale because he profited from the grapes; he hires Julius as coachman.

Background: Published in The Atlantic Monthly in 1887, the first story by an African American writer in that magazine; collected in The Conjure Woman (1899).

Significance: Chesnutt reworks the 'plantation tradition' frame to expose slavery's cruelty and Black economic agency.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Respond in writing to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Settle in and write for five minutes: Why might someone tell a story that is not literally true? No wrong answers yet; we will test these ideas against the text. Two volunteers share, and I note key words on the board. Before we start, a content note: Heads-up: this story includes slavery; heavy dialect; a racial slur used by the characters.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Introduce 5 key words: pronounce, define from context, then the word's history.
Today's words are desuetude, trellises, shiftless, monologue, shyness. For each one we read the sentence, guess from context and then check the definition. Here is the first: "Several planters thereabouts had attempted it on a commercial scale, in former years, with greater or less success; but like most Southern industries, it had felt the blight of war and had fallen into desuetude." In this sentence it means: a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up. Word histories: For the other words, look up the word history (Etymonline or the OED) and record the language of origin and the root meaning in your etymology log.

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Present the historical and literary background.
Here is what the first readers of The Goophered Grapevine would have known. Published in The Atlantic Monthly in 1887, the first story by an African American writer in that magazine; collected in The Conjure Woman (1899). Why does this story matter? Chesnutt reworks the 'plantation tradition' frame to expose slavery's cruelty and Black economic agency. Write down one question you want answered.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Teacher models a think-aloud on the anchor passage for point of view.
Watch me read this the way a careful reader does. The passage opens: "We found the weather delightful at that season, the end of summer, and were hospitably entertained." I stop and ask: what is the author doing here, and how does it connect to a story told to protect a livelihood? I circle "hospitably", one of today's words, and ask why the author chose it over a plainer word. When I find point of view, I underline it and write its effect in the margin, then I check my idea against the next sentence.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Read the anchor passage aloud together; annotate for point of view.
Now we do it together. I read the first sentence and you track along. Mark every example of point of view. Turn to a partner: what does the author want us to notice? I will collect three ideas and we choose the strongest using evidence.

> *We found the weather delightful at that season, the end of summer, and were hospitably entertained. Our host was a man of means and evidently regarded our visit as a pleasure, and we were therefore correspondingly at our ease, and in a position to act with the coolness of judgment desirable in making so radical a change in our lives. My cousin placed a horse and buggy at our disposal, and himself acted as our guide until I became somewhat familiar with the country.*

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)
Students annotate a new passage independently in the reader, then begin the writing prompt at their assigned rigor level.
Your turn. Annotate the next page in the app for Point of view, Diction / vocabulary, Irony: at least three marks with a margin note each. Then open your writing prompt; the app shows the level your teacher assigned (for a 9–10 class, the HS Sophomore prompt reads: Analyze how The Goophered Grapevine develops the idea of a story told to protect a livelihood. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) I will circulate and conference.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions (focus set for the class level): wait time, think-pair-share on DOK 3/4, follow-up probes.
Let's talk. We move from what happens to why it matters to whether it's right. After each question I wait before calling on anyone: think first. Our anchor question: How does this story connect to slavery and its memory? Every claim needs a page reference. Respond to the person before you by agreeing, extending or challenging with evidence, and end by writing one question of your own.

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)
Story quiz in the app, then a one-sentence exit ticket.
Take the story quiz in the app. Then, in one sentence, tell me what this story suggests about a story told to protect a livelihood, backed by one short quotation.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
Today we saw how point of view shapes a story told to protect a livelihood. Tonight, read the next story and add two words to your etymology log.

Total: 90 minutes.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
desuetude (noun)	a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up	*Several planters thereabouts had attempted it on a commercial scale, in former years, with greater or less success; but like most Southern industries, it had felt the blight of war and had fallen into desuetude.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
trellises (noun)	frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow	*The vines—here partly supported by decayed and broken-down trellises, there twining themselves among the branches of the slender saplings which had sprung up among them—grew in wild and unpruned luxuriance, and the few scattered grapes they bore were the undisputed prey of the first comer.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
shiftless (adjective)	lazy and lacking ambition	*The estate had been for years involved in litigation between disputing heirs, during which period shiftless cultivation had well-nigh exhausted the soil.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
monologue (noun)	a long speech by one person	*As he became more and more absorbed in the narrative, his eyes assumed a dreamy expression, and he seemed to lose sight of his auditors, and to be living over again in monologue his life on the old plantation.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
shyness (noun)	a feeling of fear of embarrassment	*After a little patient investigation, necessary to overcome the child's shyness, we learned what we wished to know, and at the end of about five miles from the town reached our destination.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
imparted (verb)	gave; passed on	*He imparted this information with such solemn earnestness, and with such an air of confidential mystery, that I felt somewhat interested, while Annie was evidently much impressed, and drew closer to me.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
equivalent (noun)	a person or thing equal to another in value or	*I believe, however, that the wages I paid him for his services as coachman, for I gave him employment in that capacity,*	

	measure or force or effect or significance etc	*were more than an equivalent for anything he lost by the sale of the vineyard.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
litigation (noun)	the process of taking a dispute to court	*The estate had been for years involved in litigation between disputing heirs, during which period shiftless cultivation had well-nigh exhausted the soil.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
luscious (adjective)	richly sweet and delicious	*The luscious scuppernong holds first rank among our grapes, though we cultivate a great many other varieties, and our income from grapes packed and shipped to the Northern markets is quite considerable.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)
hospitably (adverb)	in a warm, welcoming way toward guests	*We found the weather delightful at that season, the end of summer, and were hospitably entertained.*	Student look-up (not yet verified)

Discussion questions

1. Why might someone tell a story that is not literally true?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with slavery and its memory?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Middle School: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. Why does John come to North Carolina? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: His wife needs a milder climate and he seeks a business
2. Who tells the tale of the vineyard? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Uncle Julius McAdoo
3. What is a 'goopher'? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A conjure spell
4. What happens to Henry with the seasons? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: He grows young and strong with the vines, then weak
5. What does John suspect about Julius's story? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Julius profited from the grapes and wanted to keep them
6. Retell the three most important events of “The Goophered Grapevine” in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A white Northerner, John, considers buying a run-down North Carolina vineyard. Julius McAdoo, a formerly enslaved man, tells him it is 'goophered' (conjured): before the war, an enslaved man named Henry ate its grapes, and his life rose and fell with the vines until he died. John buys anyway and later suspects Julius told the tale because he profited from the grapes; he hires Julius as coachman.

7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in “The Goophered Grapevine”? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does “The Goophered Grapevine” take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: “Several planters thereabouts had attempted it on a commercial scale, in former years, with greater or less success; but like most Southern industries, it had felt the blight of war and had fallen into desuetude.” What does “desuetude” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: desuetude: a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up.
10. Reread: “The vines—here partly supported by decayed and broken-down trellises, there twining themselves among the branches of the slender saplings which had sprung up among them—grew in wild and unpruned luxuriance, and the few…” What does “trellises” mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.7.1, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.1] Look for: trellises: frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does “The Goophered Grapevine” suggest about a story told to protect a livelihood? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: Chesnutt reworks the 'plantation tradition' frame to expose slavery's cruelty and Black economic agency.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the diction / vocabulary in this story shape what we understand about a story told to protect a livelihood? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for precise or unusual word choices and their connotations.
4. In the passage that begins “We found the weather delightful at that season, the end of summer, and were hospitably entertained.”, why might Chesnutt have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.4, SL.7.1, 7.RC.12, 7.CC.2] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in “The Goophered Grapevine”, and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A white Northerner, John, considers buying a run-down North Carolina vineyard. Julius McAdoo, a formerly enslaved man, tells him it is 'goophered' (conjured): before the war, an enslaved man named Henry ate its grapes, and his life rose and fell with the vines until he died. John buys anyway and…
6. As the opening story, what does “The Goophered Grapevine” set up that the rest of The Goophered Grapevine will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.

8. The bell-ringer asked: “Why might someone tell a story that is not literally true?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does irony appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with slavery and its memory? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.2] Look for: Look for gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true.
10. Background: Published in The Atlantic Monthly in 1887, the first story by an African American writer in that magazine; collected in The Conjure Woman (1899). How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.2] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “Chesnutt reworks the 'plantation tradition' frame to expose slavery's cruelty and Black economic agency.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.
3. Rewrite one moment of “The Goophered Grapevine” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about a story told to protect a livelihood? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.
4. Write three questions of your own about “The Goophered Grapevine”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.
5. Connect this story to storytelling as resistance: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Chesnutt need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.
6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.7.6, SL.7.1, 7.RC.1, 7.CC.3] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.
7. Compare how “The Goophered Grapevine” treats a story told to protect a livelihood with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Goophered Grapevine see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.
8. As the final story, does this ending resolve slavery and its memory? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.3, SL.7.1, 7.RC.3, 7.CC.3] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.
9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about a story told to protect a livelihood? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

10. What question would you most like to ask Charles W. Chesnutt about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.7.2, SL.7.1, 7.RC.2, 7.CC.3] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Diction / vocabulary**: precise or unusual word choices and their connotations
- Also notice **Irony**: gaps between what characters expect or say and what is true

Chapter quiz

1. Why does John come to North Carolina?
   A. To fight in a war
   B. To teach
   C. His wife needs a milder climate and he seeks a business
   D. To visit family
2. Who tells the tale of the vineyard?
   A. The narrator's wife
   B. Aunt Peggy
   C. Uncle Julius McAdoo
   D. Henry
3. What is a 'goopher'?
   A. A ghost
   B. A conjure spell
   C. A kind of grape
   D. A plantation tool
4. What happens to Henry with the seasons?
   A. He becomes free
   B. He escapes north
   C. He grows young and strong with the vines, then weak
   D. He is sold
5. What does John suspect about Julius's story?
   A. Julius was afraid
   B. Julius wanted to buy the land
   C. Julius profited from the grapes and wanted to keep them
   D. It was all true

6. In the line “Several planters thereabouts had attempted it on a commercial scale, in former years, with greater or less success; but like most Southern industries, it had felt the blight of war and had fallen into desuetude.”, what does “desuetude” most nearly mean?
   A. a long speech by one person
   B. lazy and lacking ambition
   C. frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow
   D. a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up
7. In the line “The vines—here partly supported by decayed and broken-down trellises, there twining themselves among the branches of the slender saplings which had sprung up among them—grew in wild and unpruned luxuriance, and the few scattered grapes they bore were the undisputed prey of the first comer.”, what does “trellises” most nearly mean?
   A. lazy and lacking ambition
   B. a long speech by one person
   C. a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up
   D. frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow

Answer key: 1. C (His wife needs a milder climate and he seeks a business); 2. C (Uncle Julius McAdoo); 3. B (A conjure spell); 4. C (He grows young and strong with the vines, then weak); 5. C (Julius profited from the grapes and wanted to keep them); 6. D (a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up); 7. D (frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow)

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Middle School (250 words; Common Core: RL.7.6, W.7.1; Indiana 2023: 7.RC.1, 7.W.1): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track; this story is above the grades 6–8 complexity band, so work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Goophered Grapevine,” how does Chesnutt show a story told to protect a livelihood? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): In The Goophered Grapevine, how does Chesnutt develop the idea of a story told to protect a livelihood? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.6, W.9-10.1; Indiana 2023: 9-10.RC.1, 9-10.W.1): Analyze how The Goophered Grapevine develops the idea of a story told to protect a livelihood. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and diction / vocabulary shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.3, 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO3): Analyze how the structure of The Goophered Grapevine (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of a story told to protect a livelihood. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO5): Two readers disagree about what The Goophered Grapevine suggests about a story told to protect a livelihood. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's point of view and diction / vocabulary), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; AP: AP-LIT.NAR, AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1; Indiana 2023: 11-12.RC.1, 11-12.W.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Charles W. Chesnutt uses point of view in The Goophered Grapevine to complicate the reader's understanding of a story told to protect a livelihood. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.3, ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.1): Situate The Goophered Grapevine within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of a story told to protect a livelihood responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-LIT-1, LeL-C2-W-1): Read The Goophered Grapevine alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of a story told to protect a livelihood follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-LIT-1, LeL-C3-W-1): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Goophered Grapevine and its treatment of a story told to protect a livelihood. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and diction / vocabulary, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-LIT-1, LeL-C4-W-1): Develop a research argument that reads The Goophered Grapevine as evidence for a larger claim about a story told to protect a livelihood in The Goophered Grapevine. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-LIT-1, LeL-GR-W-1): Develop an original argument that reads The Goophered Grapevine as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of a story told to protect a livelihood. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Goophered Grapevine.

SAT-style questions

1. *The estate had been for years involved in litigation between disputing heirs, during which period shiftless cultivation had well-nigh exhausted the soil.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “shiftless” most nearly mean?

   A. lazy and lacking ambition

B. in a warm, welcoming way toward guests

C. richly sweet and delicious

D. the process of taking a dispute to court

2. *We found the weather delightful at that season, the end of summer, and were hospitably entertained. Our host was a man of means and evidently regarded our visit as a pleasure, and we were therefore correspondingly at our ease, and in a position to act with the coolness of judgment desirable in making so radical a change in our lives. My cousin placed a horse and buggy at our disposal, and himself acted as our guide until I became somewhat familiar with the country.*

Which choice best states a central concern of "The Goophered Grapevine"?

A. A story told to protect a livelihood

B. Superstition used against a credulous man

C. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

D. Revenge carried out with perfect control

SAT key: 1. A (lazy and lacking ambition); 2. A (A story told to protect a livelihood)

Whole-book test

The Goophered Grapevine: whole-book test · 90 minutes

Part I: Multiple choice

1. Why does John come to North Carolina?
   A. To fight in a war
   B. To teach
   C. His wife needs a milder climate and he seeks a business
   D. To visit family
2. Who tells the tale of the vineyard?
   A. The narrator's wife
   B. Aunt Peggy
   C. Uncle Julius McAdoo
   D. Henry
3. What is a 'goopher'?
   A. A ghost
   B. A conjure spell
   C. A kind of grape
   D. A plantation tool
4. What happens to Henry with the seasons?
   A. He becomes free
   B. He escapes north
   C. He grows young and strong with the vines, then weak
   D. He is sold
5. What does John suspect about Julius's story?
   A. Julius was afraid
   B. Julius wanted to buy the land
   C. Julius profited from the grapes and wanted to keep them
   D. It was all true
6. In the line “Several planters thereabouts had attempted it on a commercial scale, in former years, with greater or less success; but like most Southern industries, it had felt the blight of war and had fallen into desuetude.”, what does “desuetude” most nearly mean?
   A. a long speech by one person
   B. lazy and lacking ambition
   C. frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow
   D. a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up

7. In the line “The vines—here partly supported by decayed and broken-down trellises, there twining themselves among the branches of the slender saplings which had sprung up among them—grew in wild and unpruned luxuriance, and the few scattered grapes they bore were the undisputed prey of the first comer.”, what does “trellises” most nearly mean?
   A. lazy and lacking ambition
   B. a long speech by one person
   C. a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up
   D. frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow
8. As used in the story (“Several planters thereabouts had attempted it on a commercial scale, in former years, with greater or less success; but like most Southern i”), what does “desuetude” mean?
   A. a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up
   B. a feeling of fear of embarrassment
   C. the process of taking a dispute to court
   D. frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow
9. As used in the story (“The vines—here partly supported by decayed and broken-down trellises, there twining themselves among the branches of the slender saplings wh”), what does “trellises” mean?
   A. gave; passed on
   B. frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow
   C. richly sweet and delicious
   D. lazy and lacking ambition
10. As used in the story (“The estate had been for years involved in litigation between disputing heirs, during which period shiftless cultivation had well-nigh exhaus”), what does “shiftless” mean?
    A. a person or thing equal to another in value or measure or force or effect or significance etc
    B. in a warm, welcoming way toward guests
    C. lazy and lacking ambition
    D. a long speech by one person
11. As used in the story (“As he became more and more absorbed in the narrative, his eyes assumed a dreamy expression, and he seemed to lose sight of his auditors, and”), what does “monologue” mean?
    A. the process of taking a dispute to court
    B. a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up
    C. a feeling of fear of embarrassment
    D. a long speech by one person
12. As used in the story (“After a little patient investigation, necessary to overcome the child's shyness, we learned what we wished to know, and at the end of about ”), what does “shyness” mean?
    A. a feeling of fear of embarrassment
    B. richly sweet and delicious
    C. frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow
    D. gave; passed on

Part II: Short answer

1. Explain how slavery and its memory develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
2. Explain how storytelling as resistance develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.
3. Explain how race and economics develops from the beginning of the story to the end. Use two passages.

Part III: Essay

Choose one of the story's central concerns (slavery and its memory, storytelling as resistance, race and economics) and argue how the ending reframes it.

Answer key

Answer key: 1. C (His wife needs a milder climate and he seeks a business); 2. C (Uncle Julius McAdoo); 3. B (A conjure spell); 4. C (He grows young and strong with the vines, then weak); 5. C (Julius profited from the grapes and wanted to keep them); 6. D (a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up); 7. D (frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow); 8. A (a state of disuse; no longer being used or kept up); 9. B (frames of crossed strips on which climbing plants grow); 10. C (lazy and lacking ambition); 11. D (a long speech by one person); 12. A (a feeling of fear of embarrassment)

Essay assignments

Essay: Slavery and its memory

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Goophered Grapevine teaches about slavery and its memory. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Charles W. Chesnutt develops slavery and its memory in The Goophered Grapevine. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Charles W. Chesnutt develops slavery and its memory across The Goophered Grapevine. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Goophered Grapevine (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of slavery and its memory. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of slavery and its memory in The Goophered Grapevine. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Charles W. Chesnutt's choices in The Goophered Grapevine (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of slavery and its memory, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Goophered Grapevine's treatment of slavery and its memory in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on slavery and its memory in The Goophered Grapevine that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on slavery and its memory in The Goophered Grapevine. Name your

critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about slavery and its memory in The Goophered Grapevine, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on slavery and its memory in The Goophered Grapevine, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Storytelling as resistance

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Goophered Grapevine teaches about storytelling as resistance. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Charles W. Chesnutt develops storytelling as resistance in The Goophered Grapevine. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Charles W. Chesnutt develops storytelling as resistance across The Goophered Grapevine. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Goophered Grapevine (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of storytelling as resistance. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of storytelling as resistance in The Goophered Grapevine. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Charles W. Chesnutt's choices in The Goophered Grapevine (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of storytelling as resistance, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Goophered Grapevine's treatment of storytelling as resistance in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on storytelling as resistance in The Goophered Grapevine that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on storytelling as resistance in The Goophered Grapevine. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about storytelling as resistance in The Goophered Grapevine, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on storytelling as resistance in The Goophered Grapevine, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Race and economics

Middle School (600 words; Common Core: W.7.1, RL.7.2; Indiana 2023: 7.W.1, 7.RC.2): Excerpt-based (Middle School support track): write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Goophered Grapevine teaches about race and economics. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Charles W. Chesnutt develops race and economics in The Goophered Grapevine. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2; Indiana 2023: 9-10.W.1, 9-10.RC.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Charles W. Chesnutt develops race and economics across The Goophered Grapevine. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.3; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO2): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Goophered Grapevine (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of race and economics. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO5): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of race and economics in The Goophered Grapevine. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; AP: AP-LIT.LAN; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2; Indiana 2023: 11-12.W.1, 11-12.RC.1; Cambridge International: CAIE-9695.AO3, CAIE-9695.AO4): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Charles W. Chesnutt's choices in The Goophered Grapevine (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of race and economics, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Dual Credit (Indiana College Core): ICC-WC-1.5, ICC-WC-1.4, ICC-WC-1.7): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Goophered Grapevine's treatment of race and economics in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C2-W-1, LeL-C2-LIT-1): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on race and economics in The Goophered Grapevine that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C3-W-1, LeL-C3-LIT-1): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on race and economics in The Goophered Grapevine. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-C4-W-1, LeL-C4-LIT-1): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about race and economics in The Goophered Grapevine, engaging at least four scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Liber et Libri program outcomes: LeL-GR-W-1, LeL-GR-LIT-1): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on race and economics in The Goophered Grapevine, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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